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abjad or  is a writing system in which only **consonants** are represented, leaving the vowels to be inferred by the reader. This contrasts with **alphabets**, which provide **graphemes** for both consonants and vowels. The term was coined in 1990 by **Peter T. Daniels**.^[4] Other terms for the same concept include **partial phonemic script**, **segmental alphabetic script**, **phonotactic script**, **consonantal writing**, and **consonantal alphabet**.^[5]

Impure abjads represent vowels with either optional *diacritics*, a limited number of distinct vowel glyphs, or both.

Etymology [edit]

The name *abjad* is based on the *Arabic alphabet*'s first (in its *original order*) four letters—corresponding to *a*, *b*, *j*, and *d*—to replace the more common terms "consonantary" and "consonantal alphabet" in describing the family of scripts classified as "*West Semitic*." It

is similar to other Semitic languages such as [Phoenician](#), [Hebrew](#) and [Semitic](#) proto-alphabets: specifically, [aleph](#)

Terminology [edit]

According to the formulations of Peter T. Daniels,¹⁹ abjads differ from alphabets in that only consonants, not vowels, are represented among the basic graphemes. Abjads differ from abugidas, another category defined by Daniels, in that in abjads, the vowel sound is implied by phonology, and where vowel marks exist for the system, such as *nikkud* for Hebrew and *ṣarāḳāt* for Arabic, their use is optional and not the dominant (or iterative) form. Abjads mark all vowels (other than the “inherent” vowel) with a *dacritic*, a minor attachment to the letter, a standalone *glyph*, or (in Canadian Aboriginal syllabics) by rotation of the letter. Some abjads use a

denotes a complete syllable

The contrast of abjad versus alphabet has been rejected by other scholars because *abjad* is also used as a term for the Arabic numeral system. Also, it may be taken as suggesting that consonantal alphabets, in contrast to e.g. the [Greek alphabet](#), were not yet true alphabets.^[7] [Florian Coulmas](#), a critic of Daniels and of the abjad terminology, argues that this terminology can confuse alphabets with "transcription systems", and that there is no reason to relegate the Hebrew, Aramaic or Phoenician alphabets to second-class status as an "incomplete alphabet".^[8] However, Daniels's terminology has found acceptance in the linguistic community.^{[9][10][11]}

Origins [[edit](#)]

See also: *[History of the alphabet § Descendants of the Aramaic abjad](#)*



The first abjad to gain widespread usage was the **Phoenician abjad**. Unlike other contemporary scripts, such as **cuneiform** and **Egyptian hieroglyphs**, the Phoenician script consisted of only a few dozen symbols. This made the script easy to learn, and seafaring Phoenician merchants took the script throughout the then-known world.

The Phoenician abjad was a radical simplification of phonetic writing, since hieroglyphics required the writer to pick a hieroglyph starting with the same sound that the writer wanted to write in order to write phonetically, much as *man'yōgana* (kanji used solely for



A specimen of **Proto-Sinaitic** script

Phonetic use) was used to represent **japanese** phonetically, before the invention of **kana**. **Baatar**. The line running from the upper left to lower right reads *mt l b'it*.

Other sister scripts to Phoenician, that branched from **Proto-Sinaitic script** are the **South Semitic scripts** with its two main branches:

the **Ancient North Arabian** scripts that were used in north and central Arabia, until it was displaced by the **Arabic alphabet**.^[12] and

Ancient South Arabian, which evolved later into the Ge'ez script, still being used in Eritrea and Ethiopia.

Impure abjads have chara

pure' abjad refers to scripts entirely lacking in vowel indicators.^[14] However, most modern abjads, such as **Arabic**, **Hebrew**, **Aramaic**, and **Pahlavi**, are "impure" abjads – that is, they also contain symbols for some of the vowel phonemes, although the said non-diacritic vowel letters are also used to write the consonants, particularly *approximants* that sound similar to long vowels. A "pure" abjad is exemplified (perhaps) by very early forms of ancient **Phoenician**, although at some point (at least by the 9th century BC) it and most of the contemporary Semitic abjads had begun to overload a few of the consonant symbols with a secondary function as vowel markers, called *matres lectionis*.^[14] This practice was at first rare and limited in scope but became increasingly common and more developed in later times.

Addition of vowels [edit]

Main article: [Greek alphabet](#)

In the 9th century BC the Greeks adapted the Phoenician script for use in their own language. The phonetic structure of the Greek language created too many ambiguities when vowels went unrepresented, so the script was modified. They did not need letters for

were also adapted into vowel signs

Greek was to dedicate these symbols exclusively and unambiguously to vowel sounds that could be combined arbitrarily with consonants (as opposed to syllabaries such as [Linear B](#) which usually have vowel symbols but cannot combine them with consonants to form arbitrary syllables).

Abujadas developed along a slightly different route. The basic consonantal symbol was considered to have an inherent "a" vowel sound. Hooks or short lines attached to various parts of the basic letter modify the vowel. In this way, the [South Arabian abjad](#) evolved into the [Ge'ez script](#) of Ethiopia between the 5th century BC and the 5th century AD. Similarly, the [Brāhmī abujada](#) of the Indian subcontinent developed around the 3rd century BC (from the [Aramaic abjad](#), it has been hypothesized).

Abjads and the structure of Semitic languages

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The abjad form of writing is well-adapted to the **morphological** structure of the Semitic languages it was developed to write. This is because words in writing (lexical forms) are formed from a **root** consisting of (usually) **three consonants**, the vowels being used to indicate inflectional or derived forms. For instance, according to **Classical Arabic** and **Modern Standard Arabic**, from the Arabic root **ك-ت-ب** (K-T-B) (to write) can be derived the forms **كاتب** *katāba* (he wrote), **كاتبة** *katābta* (you (feminine singular) wrote), **يكتب** *yaktubu* (he writes), and **مكتبة** *maktabah* (library). In most cases, the absence of full glyphs for vowels makes the common root clearer, allowing readers to guess the meaning of unfamiliar words from familiar roots (especially in conjunction with **context** clues) and improving word recognition^[*citation needed*]*dubious – discuss* while reading for practiced readers.

Adaptation for use as true alphabets [edit]

The Arabic abjad have been adapted to perform as **true alphabets** when used to write several languages, including **Kurdish**, **Swahili**, **Malay**, and **Uyghur**, and historically, **Romani**, **Mznanbar**, **Aganones**, **Portuguese**, **Spanish** and **Arifkay**, with some letters or letter

combinations being repurposed to represent vowels. The
and Yiddish.

Comparative chart of abjads, extinct and extant [[edit](#)]

[illegible]

Arabic	yes	yes	right-left	28	3	Middle East	Over 400 million people	Pashto, Uyghur, Kurdish, Urdu, many others ^[15]	512 CE ^[16]
Syriac	yes	yes	right-left	22 consonants	3	Middle East	Syriac Christianity, Assyrians	Aramaic: Syriac, Assyrian Neo-Aramaic, Turoyo, Mlahso	c. 10 BCE
Hebrew	yes	yes	right-left	22 consonants + 5 final letters	4	Middle East	Israelis, Jewish diaspora communities, Second Temple Judea	Hebrew, Judeo-Arabic, Judeo-Aramaic, Judeo-Persian, Judeo-Italian, Yiddish, Ladino, many others	2nd BCE
Aramaic (Imperial)	no	no	right-left	22	3	Middle East	Achaemenid, Persian, Babylonian, and Assyrian empires	Imperial Aramaic, Hebrew	c. 500 BCE
Aramaic (Early)	no	no	right-left	22	none	Middle East	Various Semitic Peoples		c. 1000 c. 900 ^[citation needed]
Nabataean	no	no	right-left	22	none	Middle East	Nabataean Kingdom ^[17]	Nabataean	200
Phoenician	no	no	right-left, boustrophedon	22	none	Byblos ^[15]	Canaanites	Phoenician, Punic, Hebrew	c. 1500 c. 100 BCE
Punic	no	no	right-left	22	none	Carthage (Tunisia), North Africa, Mediterranean ^[15]	Punic Culture	Punic, Neo-Punic	
Ancient North Arabian	no	no	right-left	29	yes	Arabian Peninsula	Northern Arabians	Old Arabic,Ancient North Arabian languages	8th century BCE
Ancient South Arabian	no	yes (Zabūr - cursive form of the South Arabian script)	right-left, boustrophedon	29	yes	South-Arabia (Yemen)	D'mt Kingdom	Amharic, Tigrinya, Tigre, Semitic, Cushitic, Nilo-Saharan ^[citation needed]	900 ^[citation needed]
Sabaeen	no	no	right-left, boustrophedon	29	none	Southern Arabia (Sheba)	Southern Arabians	Sabaeen	c. 500 BCE
Parthian	no	no	right-left	22	yes	Parthia (modern-day equivalent of Northeastern Iran, Southern Turkmenistan and Northwest Afghanistan) ^[15]	Parthian & Sassanian periods of Persian Empire ^[15]	Parthian	c. 200 BCE
Ugaritic	no	yes	left-right	30	none, 3 characters for gs +vowel	Ugarit (modern-day Northern Syria)	Ugarites	Ugaritic, Hurrian	c. 1400 BCE
Proto-Sinaitic, Proto-Canaanite	no	no	left-right	24	none	Egypt, Sinai, Canaan	Canaanites	Canaanite	c. 1500 c. 1700
Samaritan	yes (700 people)	no	right-left	22	none	Levant	Samaritans (Nablus and Holon)	Samaritan Aramaic, Samaritan Hebrew	c. 1000 c. 100
Tifinagh	yes	no	bottom-top, right-left, left-right,	31	yes	North Africa	Berbers	Berber languages	2nd millennium BCE
Middle Persian, (Pahlavi)	no	no	right-left	22	3	Middle East	Sassanian Empire	Pahlavi, Middle Persian	c. 200 c. 700
Psalter Pahlavi	no	yes	right-left	21	yes	Northwestern China ^[15]	Persian Script for Paper Writing ^[15]		c. 400
Sogdian	no	no (yes in later versions)	right-left, left-right (vertical)	20	3	parts of China (Xinjiang), Uzbekistan, Tajikistan, Pakistan	Buddhists, Manichaens	Sogdian	c. 400

- **Abjad numeral**

- [Abjad](#)
 - [Disemvoweling](#)
 - [Gematria](#) (Hebrew & English system of alphanumeric code)
 - [Numerology](#)
 - [Shorthand](#) (constructed writing systems that are structurally abjads)
- ## References
- [[edit](#)]

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2. ^ Boyes, Philip J

- 1925-1932].
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- [The Science of Arabic](#)

- | Writing systems |
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